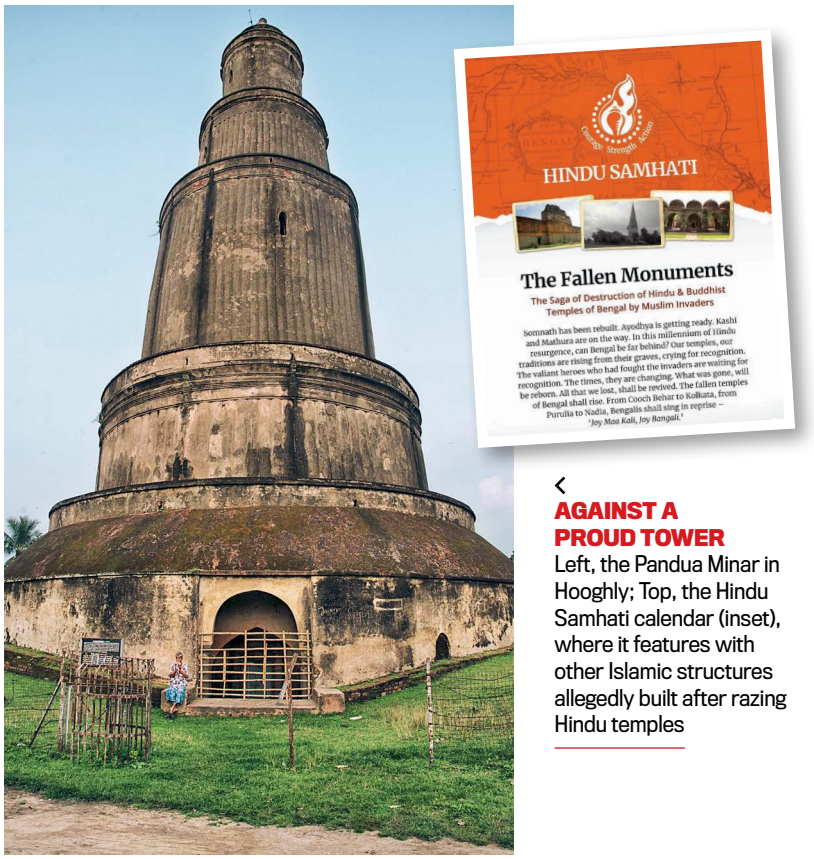
It was supposed to be a soiree celebrating the birth anniversaries of two great Bengali poets—Rabindranath Tagore and Kazi Nazrul Islam—in the sprawling *nat mandir* (dance hall) of Radha Govinda Jiu temple at Nabadwip, in West Bengal's Nadia district. But, an hour before its start on May 24, amidst sudden commotion, the organisers were made to remove a picture of Nazrul and delete his name from the title—Rabindra-Nazrul Sandhya—by temple authorities. Later, it emerged they had bowed to 'pressure' from the BJP, who did not appreciate the celebration of a Muslim poet in a Hindu temple space.

The targeting of Nazrul by the BJP has a history. As an icon who in many ways bridges the religious chasm that has scarred Bengal, he may not be particularly easy to villainise, but typifies the culture of exchange and reciprocity the party tends to look askance at. So it was entirely in character when, during the 1999 Lok Sabha campaign, Bengal BJP leader Tapan Sikdar disparaged him as a "*modhyo-medhar Mussalman kobi*" (a second-rate Muslim poet). To that extent, the basic instinct is familiar from other saffron laboratories: go hard at spaces and figures of syncretism who create a climate opposite to one conducive to Hindutva. But under that broad umbrella, the BJP's ongoing advance into West Bengal politics has been seeing a perceptible shift—a conscious tactical adaptation to the local habitus.

Over a decade, the BJP's shrill denunciation of the Trinamool Congress (TMC)—especially for "appeasement of Muslims"—had been partly compromised by the *kind* of Hindutva it espoused. It had a distinct north Indian flavour—revolving around clangorous processions on Hanuman Jayanti and Ramnavami, not deities with as high a currency in Gangetic Bengal as they have upriver in the north. Along with this was an uncomfortable cultural distance from Bengal's own religious traditions—more aligned to Shaktism, with the primary veneration of figures like Durga and Kali, not to speak of attendant sacrificial rituals and blanket non-vegetarianism. This is what enabled chief minister Mamata Banerjee to lay the "outsider" charge on them with such rhetorical force during the 2021 assembly election campaign, as she played her own nativist politics. But a new emphasis had been already emerging: this involves picking up and coopting themes native to Bengal, dredging out from its landscape half-forgotten temples and rituals, hyperlocal traditions and autochthonous deities reimagined in mainstream 'Hindu' ways, even inventing 'ancient' pilgrimages. That this revivalist strategy goes with a stealthy parading of mosques or other monuments allegedly built after demolishing temples during the Bengal Sultanate is par for the Hindutva course.



AGAINST A PROUD TOWER
Left, the Pandua Minar in Hooghly; Top, the Hindu Samhati calendar (inset), where it features with other Islamic structures allegedly built after razing Hindu temples

SEARCH FOR A KUMBH MELA

In a bid to stake a claim to things both inherently 'Bengali' and 'Hindu', the BJP is engaged in ferreting out places with a naturalistic claim to antiquity. One of them is the Tribeni sangam in Hooghly district, where the Bhagirathi Hooghly, one of the branches of the main Ganga, splits into three distributaries named Ganga (Hooghly), Jamuna and Saraswati. The BJP claims this was a site of a local Kumbh mela till one Zafar Khan Ghazi, whose 13th-century dargah and mosque stand nearby, allegedly put an end to it. This year, both the Union culture ministry and the TMC—unwilling to let go of any beneficial symbolism—spent crores to